Protest in Sports

Today, protests in sports are rather regular; thus, we examine one such demonstration in India that shocked the entire globe.

The two FIRs that wrestlers have filed against the president of the Indian Wrestling Federation and BJP MP Brij Bhushan Singh allege at least two instances of "sexual favors" being demanded in place of professional assistance, at least 15 instances of sexual harassment, including 10 instances of inappropriate touching and molestation that included touching the navel and running hands over the breasts, and numerous instances of intimidation, including stalking. The Indian wrestling community has recently experienced a wave of demonstrations driven by valiant athletes who are calling for reform within the sport. Due to their tenacity and tenacity, wrestlers have turned to the streets and social media to speak out against a variety of topics. This blog investigates the causes of the demonstrations and clarifies their importance in the history of Indian wrestling and protests in sports.

Demanding Recognition and Support:

The wrestlers' desire for the government and sporting authorities to recognize and assist them is one of the main causes of the demonstrations. Despite the long history of the sport and the participants' outstanding accomplishments, wrestling frequently lacks funding, support systems, and infrastructure. Wrestlers protest to draw attention to their hardships and to the fact that they require adequate funding, training facilities, and other resources to compete at the top level.

Equal Opportunities and Inclusivity:

The need for inclusion and fair opportunity within the wrestling community is a significant factor behind the demonstrations. Wrestlers are advocating for impartial treatment, fair selection procedures, and an end to discrimination based on gender, caste, or socioeconomic status. They seek to create an atmosphere where every prospective wrestler has the opportunity to succeed because they feel that skill and hard effort should be the only criteria used to choose who gets to represent the country.

Ensuring Transparent Governance:

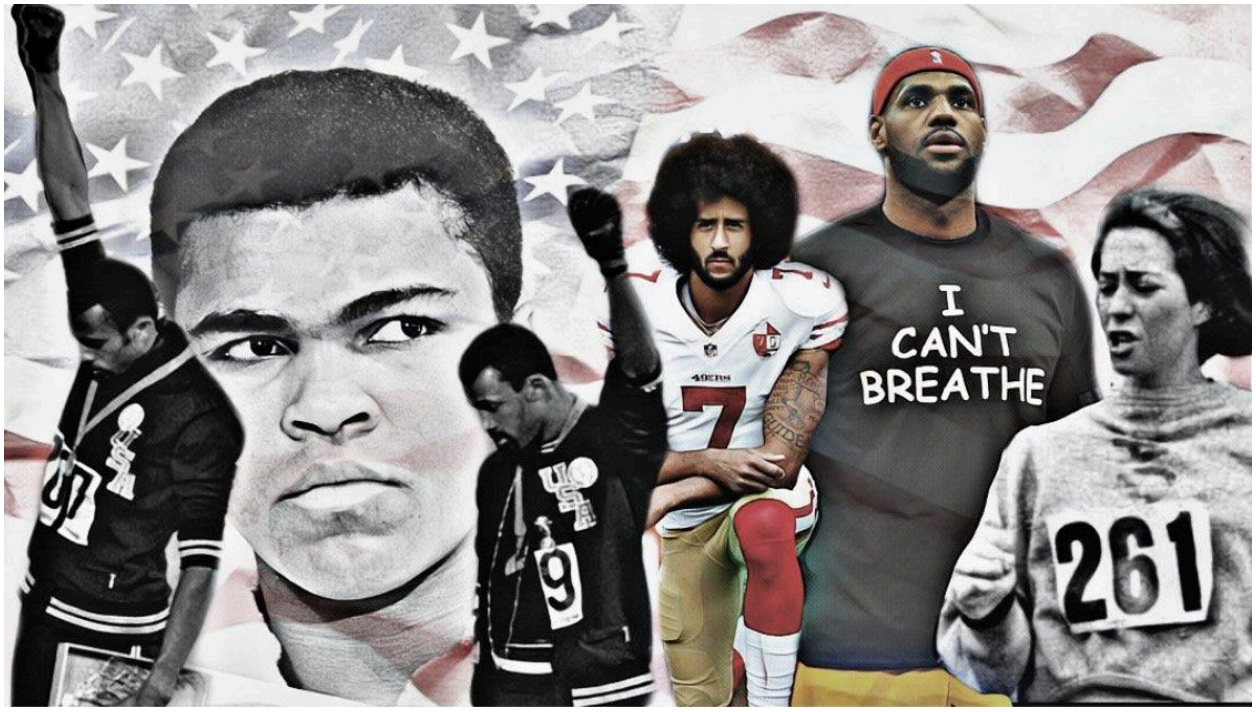
The protests also center on responsibility and transparency among wrestling associations and regulatory authorities. Wrestlers are calling for transparent selection procedures, impartial jury selection, and an end to favoritism and nepotism in decision-making. They want to make sure that each wrestler gets a fair opportunity to demonstrate their abilities and engage in competition. By promoting open government, protestors hope to increase wrestlers' trust and confidence as well as the sense of justice and integrity that exists within the sport.

Addressing Financial Security:

Another major worry for Indian wrestlers is their financial stability. Due to their low incomes, lack of sponsorship opportunities, and poor financial preparation, many athletes find it difficult to make ends meet. To protect their financial security during and after their professional careers, wrestlers are calling for higher pay, better contract terms, and access to financial awareness programs. Wrestlers battle for financial stability in the hopes of building a long-lasting community that develops and supports athletes throughout their careers.

The Power of Athlete Activism:

Athletes have been crucial in promoting societal change throughout history. Athletes have utilized their popularity to raise awareness for significant causes, from Muhammad Ali's struggle against racial inequity to Colin Kaepernick's kneeling protest against police brutality. Wrestlers, too, are recognizing the potential of athlete activism and accepting the responsibilities that come with it.



Addressing Systemic Issues:

Wrestlers are leading rallies to draw attention to several structural problems that plague the wrestling business. Pay inequities, fewer chances for marginalized groups, abusive contracts, a lack of healthcare and support networks, and a lack of diversity in narrative and representation are some of the issues raised. To establish a more secure and fair workplace for everyone engaged, wrestlers are calling for expanded inclusion, improved working conditions, equal pay, and transparency.

Who is Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, exactly?

Brij Bhushan is a seasoned administrator and politician who has served in parliament six times. He was elected to the Gonda Lok Sabha constituency in 1991 and 1999, the Balrampur seat in 2004, and the Kaiserganj seat in 2009, 2014, and 2019. Brij Bhushan, 66, a Gonda native, was involved in the Ram Janmabhoomi agitation. In the Babri Masjid demolition case, he was mentioned in his affidavit for the 2019 election.

What offenses have the wrestlers charged Brij Bhushan with and who complained?

The wrestlers have accused the WFI of financial mismanagement and arbitrary decision-making. But sexual harassment has been the most serious accusation. The complainants have included instances that they allege occurred at Brij Bhushan's official MP's home in New Delhi, as well as during competitions both domestically and internationally, from as early as 2012 to as late as 2022. It was brought up before the Supreme Court that one of the complainants is a kid. The identity of the seven female wrestlers who reported Brij Bhushan to the police remains a secret. To safeguard their identities, CJI Chandrachud stated that the names of the complainants will be blacked out from court documents.

What actions has the government taken, exactly?

The government established an Oversight Committee in January to investigate the accusations against Brij Bhushan and oversee the day-to-day operations of the WFI to persuade the wrestlers to end their protest. The six-person group, led by boxing alumna MC Mary Kom, had four weeks to produce its recommendations. But it didn't turn in its report until the first week of April. Since then, the committee has been dissolved. Following the new demonstrations, the government ruled that the WFI elections, which were set to take place on May 7, were invalid. Additionally, it gave the IOA instructions to create an ad hoc panel that would conduct the elections within 45 days and oversee the daily operations of the WFI until the new members took over.

What are the protesting wrestlers demanding?

Due to the fact that one of the complainants is a juvenile, the wrestlers are requesting that an FIR be filed against Brij Bhushan based on their police report and that he be detained in accordance with the POCSO Act. Additionally, they have requested that the WFI be disbanded and that he be fired as president. The demonstrations that Indian wrestlers spearheaded are evidence of the enduring spirit of sportsmen who are resolved to effect change for the better. Their aspirations for respect, equality of opportunity, openness, and financial stability are essential for both their personal well-being and the expansion and advancement of the sport in the nation. These demonstrations act as a catalyst for altering the Indian wrestling scene, advancing diversity, and fostering an atmosphere that is more encouraging and long-lasting for wrestlers to thrive.